

HUSBANDS AND hysteria

THE INSANE ASYLUM

Culture has had a significant influence on how a society reacts to the mentally ill. Many ancient cultures viewed mental illness as a form of religious punishment or demonic possession and ostracized those who suffered from it. However, as early as the 5th century BCE, Greek physician Hippocrates pioneered

the treatment of mental health problems with humane techniques, without reference to religion or superstition.

In most parts of the world, if families could not care for their mentally ill loved ones, these “poor unfortunates” wandered the streets, vulnerable to assault or derision. Asylums initially came into being as a safe refuge for them. In Europe during the Middle Ages, religious orders often provided care—some hospitals run by these orders later

► Hypnotherapy

Neurologist Jean Martin Charcot uses a “magic lantern” to induce hypnosis in a patient. Women who were diagnosed with “hysteria” were often subjected to public treatments as doctors lectured to groups of students and spectators.

